

CHAPTER THREE

World War Two

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PART ONE

As I have mentioned I enlisted in the U. S. Navy on October 23, 1942, having completed successfully the exam to qualify me for training as an Electronics Technician. I went to Treasure Island (same place we had visited two years earlier for the World's Fair) for induction and boot camp training. I was there for only about 45 days as I recall. One of the persons in training camp with me was the singer, Tony Martin, who later married that fabulous dancer, Cyd Charisse. Assignment to U.S.A.C. (Utah State Agricultural College) training center in Logan, Utah followed. I lived "off campus" since I was married and had to brave the vicious winds coming down the canyon almost every morning to get to my classes. We had twelve weeks of intensive training in electricity, math, electronics, as well as lab work involving the construction of superheterodyne receiving sets. I crammed more advanced math into my head than I had ever done before, having taken only Algebra and Geometry in High School. Fortunately, since these were college level courses, I got college credits for them after the war when I matriculated at BYU.

After the A.C. training I was assigned to Corpus Christi Naval Air Station for more advanced training in aviation electronics including what was then very hush-hush, Radar. We weren't even allowed to use the word Radar off the base. One of our instructors at this training school (not in electronics but in judo) was Tyrone Power, a famous movie actor.

It turned out that Reuel Neilson was also assigned for this training although he had gone to a different preparatory school than I did. So we were able to spend the leave time that we had together if our duty schedules permitted it. We attended a branch of the Church which met in a lodge building. Every Sunday morning a group of us would go in and man the brooms to sweep out the cigarette butts and debris from the night before so that we could hold our meeting. The congregation was primarily servicemen from the air base but there were a few civilian members. One of my buddies, Don Searle, eventually married a girl whom he met at these branch meetings. Don was killed in an automobile accident shortly after the end of the war, a real tragedy for his family.

Upon completion of the course at Corpus Christi, I was promoted to Radio Technician Second Class and assigned to the Quonset Point Naval Air Station, just outside of Providence, Rhode Island, pending my assignment to a ship. While stationed at Quonset and knowing that some of my forebearers were from the Providence area, I went to a section of the library known at the Roger Williams room and

was able to read much of the early history of Providence and the part that my ancestors had played. Much later, I took my family to this same library and made some photocopies of some documents and letters relating to the Harris family role in this part of our Nation's history.

After a couple of months at Quonset Point I was assigned to a new ship, the U.S.S. Wasp, which was being outfitted in the Boston shipyards. Sometime around November 1943 I went aboard ship and remained aboard during the commission and until the war was over. Shortly after the first of the year 1944, the Wasp went on it's shakedown cruise to the Caribbean. A shakedown cruise is just that - to train a new crew and air group in the operation and functioning of the ship, as well as insure that the ship itself is functioning properly. During my stay in Boston, I had the opportunity, thanks to the good graces of a couple of Boston spinsters who had saved their gasoline rationing coupons, to visit some of the historical sites of the American Revolution, such as Concord, Bunker Hill and Lexington. Boston in the winter time was the coldest place that I had ever been in my life. I had thought braving the winds down Logan canyon the previous winter was rough but it was nothing to the high humidity freezing temperatures of Boston. I also dated on occasion a girl from Woburn and just about missed the ship's shakedown cruise by a hair because we had miscalculated the suburban train schedule and I had to stay with her and her family overnight.

The U.S.S. Wasp was an Essex class carrier with a displacement of about 35,000 tons. The original carrier by this name was sunk at the battle of the Coral Sea, and the new Wasp, scheduled to have another name, took the name of the sunken vessel. The history of the new Wasp and its sea battles of World War II is recorded in a book entitled PREP CHARLIE. I won't attempt to record chronologically the events and activities of this wartime experience even if I could recall them accurately. Following the shake down cruise and some necessary repairs and adjustments, we received orders for Pacific duty and we headed to the south Atlantic Ocean, through the Panama Canal, made a stop at San Diego, and then to Hawaii. Here, I received my first look at an actual war zone, being able to see the disastrous effects of the Pearl Harbor bombing of Dec. 7, 1942, particularly the sunken U.S.S. Arizona, much different than when Marion and I visited there in December of 1986.

The next destination for the Wasp was an atoll in the Pacific named Marcus Island. Our first successful strike against the Japanese enemy. After that when Task Force 58 moved westward commencing its grim, sweeping search for the Jap fleet, numbered amongst its front line carriers was the Wasp. The thrilling story of that tremendous Armada, the largest, swiftest and most powerful assemblage of fighting

ships the world has ever known, does not need to be recounted here. The history-making exploits of that fast carrier force--the team of Admiral Raymond Spruance and Vice Admiral John S. McCain--will be a bright page in the official account of the U. S. Navy in World War II. For me, it suffices to say that where Task Force 58 went, the WASP went sharing in the devastating blows that presaged the eclipse of Japanese control of the Western Pacific. We moved through the South China Sea to hit Indo-China (now Vietnam), helped liberate the Philippine Islands (and in this battle may very well have been the ship whose planes bombing unmarked cargo ships which were removing prisoners of war from Mindinao resulted in the death of my brother, Richard.), eliminated the Japanese resistance on the Marianas Islands, and hit the Japanese Mainland to help soften it up for what seemed like a necessary invasion.

Some of the engagements were pretty exciting (they were never dull!). The carrier was the central ship of a task force since upon the aircraft depended much of the offensive power of the Navy. Consequently, the carrier was surrounded and escorted by battleships, cruisers, and destroyers which were constantly patrolling to detect hostile aircraft and submarines. During the dangerous foray the Task Force made into the South China Sea to neutralize Japanese strength in what was then known as French Indo-China (now Vietnam), our ships had to pass extremely close to the island of Formosa (now Taiwan) which was under Japanese control. While we slipped through undetected on our way to Indo-China, there was no way that we could remain so, once having launched our aerial bombardment of the Japanese military centers there. On our way out, we quite literally had to fight our way through and the Japanese were constantly trying to damage the central ship, the carrier. Several of our ships were damaged and our movement was slowed considerably. I recall a late evening attack by Japanese bombers called "Zeros" when torpedoes were deliberately taken by our escorting cruisers rather than let the carrier, the Wasp, be hit. It was quite sobering to know that you were witnessing others sacrificing their lives to protect the ship you were on.

In March 1945, off the coast of Japan our ship took a bomb which did extensive damage to the lower decks, the hangar deck and the mess deck. This required the ship to return to Pearl Harbor and subsequently to the States (Bremerton, Washington) for extensive repairs. A couple of things happened while the ship was under repair in Bremerton, Washington. On April 12, 1945, President Franklin D. Roosevelt died of a cerebral hemorrhage and Harry Truman became the president. Also the President of the LDS church died (Heber J. Grant) in May. Both of these men had held their offices much of my life time. After these repairs, we returned to the war zone (early June 1945). After our raids

on the Philippines, preparations were made for a major raid on the Japanese mainland. At the time of the dropping of the atomic bombs on Hiroshima and Nagasaki, our Task Force was off the coast of Japan, 100 miles or so. We had been conducting raids by carrier-based planes and, of course, knew nothing about the existence of atomic weapons. In fact, at the time the news was flashed to us, about a super weapon being used, the significance of entering the atomic age was lost on us. This was August 1945 and we continued in the combat zone for several months thereafter. Word came eventually of the surrender of the Japanese as a result of the atomic bombs and the subsequent signing of the documents on the battleship Missouri which ended the war in the Far East. However, we still had some holdout Kamikazes and even after the surrender was signed our ship was attacked by one of them, resulting, fortunately, in only a near miss.

V.E. day in Europe had occurred in June of 1945. Under the point system which determined when a serviceman would be discharged, I was able to leave the Wasp at Pearl Harbor and after a wait of about four to six weeks, returned to the U. S. via a small "jeep" carrier to San Francisco, and then a battleship to Bremerton, Washington where I received my discharge in Nov. 1945. At mustering out I was credited with the Asiatic Pacific Ribbon with 7 stars, the Philippine Liberation Ribbon, a Good Conduct Medal, and a commendation for "above and beyond the call of duty" action in helping to fight the fire on the hangar deck of the Wasp and the time of our bomb hit in March 1945.

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There are several things which might be noted as being of interest other than the battle experiences. One of the sons of the then President Franklin D. Roosevelt, John Roosevelt, was a young officer on the Wasp. As part of Navy tradition when a ship crossed the equator there is an initiation of the "pollywogs", those who haven't crossed before, by the "shellbacks", those who have. In olden days, I'm told the shellbacks used to go as far as "keel hauling" the pollywogs, i.e. tying a line to the person and literally hauling him from one side of the ship to the other under water across the keel. Our initiation didn't go that far but it was rough enough with a lot of whacking of salt-water soaked clothes with paddles and ropes. John Roosevelt was required to stand guard duty dressed in a full diver's suit on top of a 5" gun turret (remember this was in equatorial waters.)

Some of the things I remember vividly were the typhoons and the incidents aboard ship. During one engagement, the units of the Japanese fleet had been spotted off the Philippine Islands and we set out after them,

launching our aircraft (bombers and fighter escorts) and then steaming in that direction at full speed to shorten the distance for the returning aircraft. However, because of the distance involved it was dark before the planes returned and they had to land on a deck lighted only intermittently. Most, but not all of our planes were able to land safely although some were damaged in the process. One of the aircraft which got in the landing circle and actually landed on the carrier turned out to be a Japanese aircraft. The pilot had decided it was better to land and be captured than to crash in the ocean.

On one occasion a pilot (we called him Capt. Zero because of his plane number) ignored the wave-off signal, missed the restraining cables and crashed into other aircraft which had already landed. Of course, there were also landing crew personnel who were on that part of the ship, so there were casualties to them as well as damage to the aircraft. The ship suffered major damage only on two occasions. In March 1945, off the Japanese mainland, a Japanese bomber avoided the radar screen and hit the ship amidships with a bomb which went about four decks before exploding. Fortunately, our planes had already been launched so that the ensuing fire was not as disastrous as it might have been. Nevertheless, there were several hundred casualties and sufficient damage to warrant out return to the U.S. to receive extensive repairs. The ship was also damaged pretty badly in a typhoon which ripped up about one hundred feet of the flight deck and rolled it back like a scroll. We were able to get that repaired at Guam.

There were the usual religious services aboard the ship, but it didn't take long for a number of L.D.S. servicemen to find each other and we soon had our own group services underway. At first the chaplain thought he had to be in attendance but after he saw that we knew what we were doing he soon left us on our own. At first there was another group leader whose name I have forgotten, but later at one of the ports, Commander Bond, an L.D.S. chaplain came aboard and I was set apart as the group leader. There were about twelve to fifteen of us in the group including an Ensign Fugal from Provo, Utah. One of the group was a member of the Reorganized LDS Church, but he didn't know it until we started questioning him. He continued to attend the services, however.

In reading material in the ship's library, I came across some books which provided me a lot of information on the dangers of communism. It soon occurred to me that there was a big discrepancy between what our so-called allies (the Russians) were doing in fighting the Germans and the Japanese and their political philosophy. I decided that the Soviets were going to be involved in our future for better

or for worse, probably worse. I sent for some linguaphone records in Russian and when I could started to study that language. When I matriculated at B.Y.U. after the war I switched my educational interests from electronics to political science, more in line with what my interests were even before I entered the Navy. As a student in junior high I always wanted to enter the diplomatic service so studying languages and political science seemed the logical thing to do.

Being discharged from the Navy at Bremerton was one thing but getting home was another. It was November 03, 1945 and thousands of servicemen were getting discharged and the availability of transportation was extremely limited. The Navy had provided me with enough money to get home by train but the problem was, there were no or very few trains leaving for Idaho because of a railroad strike. So I, along with a number of other fellows I knew, decided to hitch-hike. It went pretty well although there were a few times on lonely roads with it getting dark, that I wondered if it were a wise chose. As it turned out I was lucky until I got to Blackfoot, Idaho just 25 miles from home and I couldn't get a ride to save me. However, I finally found about the oldest train I have ever seen heading for Idaho Falls and managed to arrive home safe and sound. It was good to be home after five years, three of them in the service.